

D674

Elementary Social Studies Methods

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A third-grade teacher who has taught for nine years is planning a two-week unit on the local community for the spring term. She wants one question to anchor the whole inquiry, with smaller questions students can answer using sources. Which question should anchor the unit?

- A. How many lessons will fit in two weeks?
- B. In what year was our town founded?
- C. What is a community?
- D. How has our community changed, and have the changes been good for everyone?

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A unit is anchored by the compelling question “Why do people move to new places?” Which question works best as a supporting question?

- A. Where did you go on your last vacation?
- B. What reasons did families give for moving in the letters we are reading?
- C. Is moving good or bad for families?
- D. Do all people move only to find jobs?

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A second-grade class visits a town museum whose building dates to 1910. The guide shows a photograph taken at the town’s first parade in 1912, a history book about the town published in 1995, and a painting of the 1912 parade made in 2020. Which item is a primary source for the 1912 parade?

- A. The 2020 painting, because it shows the parade.
- B. All three, because they are all about 1912.
- C. The 1995 history book.
- D. The 1912 photograph.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which item is a secondary source about the first moon landing?

- A.** A recording of radio calls made during the landing.
- B.** An astronaut's handwritten mission log.
- C.** A newspaper front page printed the day after the landing.
- D.** A 2019 children's biography of an astronaut, written from interviews and records.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

Fifth graders are reading an 1890 letter in which a mill owner praises the working conditions in his mill. The letter is neatly typed and includes several statistics about wages. Next the class will compare it with an interview of a child who worked in a mill. What should the teacher have students do first with the letter?

- A.** Set it aside, because letters by owners are always false.
- B.** Use only the child's interview, because it is primary and the letter is not.
- C.** Identify who wrote it, when, and why, and consider how the owner's position could shape his claims.
- D.** Summarize the wage statistics, since numbers make it the most reliable source.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A fourth-grade teacher with a popular classroom blog is planning a lesson on why families traveled west by wagon in the 1840s. She has a wagon-train board game a parent donated. Which task best builds historical empathy?

- A.** Students use 1840s diaries and supply lists to explain what families knew and hoped for when they chose to go.
- B.** Students write how they would feel leaving their phones and video games behind.
- C.** Students decide whether the families were foolish, given what we know now about the trail's dangers.
- D.** Students play the board game to see who reaches Oregon first.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student says, “People long ago were silly for using candles instead of electric lights.” What thinking error does this show?

- A.** Historical empathy — understanding choices in their own time.
- B.** A chronology error — putting events in the wrong order.
- C.** Presentism — judging past people by today’s knowledge and technology.
- D.** Source bias — trusting a one-sided document.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A class timeline shows that a railroad reached a prairie town in 1872, the town’s population tripled by 1880, and a new school opened in 1881. The town’s founder was known for his bright red barn. A student writes that the railroad was the only reason the town grew. How should the teacher respond?

- A.** Ask the student to look for evidence of other causes, such as cheap land or farming, and weigh them.
- B.** Have the student research the red barn, since famous landmarks explain growth.
- C.** Accept the claim, since the railroad came first on the timeline.
- D.** Tell the student railroads never help towns grow.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A kindergarten teacher in a busy, newly renovated building wants to introduce maps. The district’s new world wall map arrived last week. Which first activity fits how young children build map skills?

- A.** Have students find the seven continents on the new world map.
- B.** Teach latitude and longitude with a tape grid on the floor.
- C.** Build a block model of the classroom, then draw a simple picture map of it together.
- D.** Wait until second grade, since young children cannot understand maps.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

After a month-long inquiry into litter at a nearby park, a second-grade class found that most trash piles up next to the one broken trash can. The class has an active parent volunteer group and a pet turtle. What is the best informed-action step?

- A.** Students hold a bake sale for a charity the teacher chooses.
- B.** Students send the parks department a letter with their evidence asking that the trash can be repaired.
- C.** Parent volunteers clean the park every weekend for the class.
- D.** Students take a quiz on the causes of litter.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A fourth-grade teacher in a room with new flexible seating runs a 30-minute market game in which students trade handmade goods for class tokens. Trading is lively, and the bell rings as it ends. What is the most important next step for learning?

- A.** Rearrange the flexible seating so trading runs more smoothly next time.
- B.** Lead a debrief next class linking what happened to scarcity, trade, and real markets.
- C.** Grade students on how many tokens they ended with.
- D.** Move to the next unit, since students learned by doing.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which topic should never be taught through a student role-play simulation?

- A.** Enslaved people being bought and sold.
- B.** A classroom economy with jobs and wages.
- C.** A mock town council vote on a new playground.
- D.** Any topic, because all simulations upset students.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A third-grade teacher ~~who has taught for nine years~~ is planning a two-week unit on the local community ~~for the spring term~~. She wants one question to anchor the whole inquiry, with smaller questions students can answer using sources. Which question should anchor the unit?

Target word: which question works as the compelling question **Decides:** A compelling question must be open and arguable, not a single fact.

A	Camouflage	Responds to the planning timeline, which does not decide the question type.
B	Confusion set	A factual supporting question; one source settles it, so it cannot anchor an inquiry.
C	Adjacent category	A vocabulary definition question — useful early, but not a question worth arguing about.
D	Correct	Open, enduring, and arguable; students can build an answer from several supporting questions and sources.

2. Answer B Concept 1 · transfer

A unit is anchored by the compelling question “Why do people move to new places?” Which question works best as a supporting question?

Target word: pick the supporting question — reverse of choosing the compelling one **Decides:** Supporting questions are narrower and answerable with specific sources.

A	Adjacent category	A personal connection, not a question students answer with sources.
B	Correct	Narrow, source-based, and feeds evidence back to the compelling question.
C	Inverted operation	Broad and arguable — that is another compelling question, not a supporting one.
D	Absolute language	Built on an all-or-nothing claim the sources will not support.

3. Answer D Concept 2

A second-grade class visits a town museum ~~whose building dates to 1910~~. The guide shows a photograph taken at the town’s first parade in 1912, a history book about the town published in 1995, and a painting of the 1912 parade made in 2020. Which item is a primary source for the 1912 parade?

Target word: which item is primary for this event **Decides:** Only the photograph was made at the time of the parade.

A	Adjacent category	Showing an event is not the test; it was made more than a century later.
B	Absolute language	Being about the event does not make an item primary; timing and creator do.
C	Confusion set	Written decades later to interpret the past — a secondary source.
D	Correct	Created at the event by someone present — a primary source.

4. Answer D Concept 2 • transfer

Which item is a secondary source about the first moon landing?

Target word: identify secondary — reverse of identifying primary **Decides:** A secondary source is made later by someone interpreting the event.

A	Dropped element	Ignores the “made later” element; it was captured during the event.
B	Inverted operation	Written by a participant during the event — primary.
C	Confusion set	Made at the time by witnesses to the news — treated as primary.
D	Correct	Made decades later and interprets other sources.

5. Answer C Concept 3

Fifth graders are reading an 1890 letter in which a mill owner praises the working conditions in his mill. ~~The letter is neatly typed and includes several statistics about wages.~~ Next the class will compare it with an interview of a child who worked in a mill. What should the teacher have students do first with the letter?

Target word: first step with a document **Decides:** The author has a stake in how the mill looks — sourcing comes first.

A	Absolute language	Biased sources still show what the author wanted others to believe; they are evidence.
B	Confusion set	Both are primary sources; the question is perspective, not source type.
C	Correct	Sourcing frames how much weight the content can bear before students read for details.
D	Camouflage	Responds to the neat statistics; numbers do not remove the author’s interest.

6. Answer A Concept 4

A fourth-grade teacher ~~with a popular classroom blog~~ is planning a lesson on why families traveled west by wagon in the 1840s. ~~She has a wagon train board game a parent donated.~~ Which task best builds historical empathy?

Target word: task that builds historical empathy **Decides:** Empathy means explaining choices using the evidence and values of that time.

A	Correct	Grounds perspective in period evidence and asks for an explanation, not a feeling.
B	Adjacent category	Imagines modern feelings — this is engagement, not historical perspective.
C	Inverted operation	Judges the past with hindsight — presentism, the opposite of empathy.
D	Camouflage	Uses the donated game; winning a race does not require using evidence.

7. Answer C Concept 4 • transfer

A student says, “People long ago were silly for using candles instead of electric lights.” What thinking error does this show?

Target word: name the error — reverse of choosing the empathy task **Decides:** Judging the past by what exists today.

A	Inverted operation	Names the skill the student is missing, not the error.
B	Confusion set	The order is right; the judgment is the problem.
C	Correct	Electric lights did not exist; the student applies a modern standard.
D	Adjacent category	No source is involved; it is the student’s own frame.

8. Answer A Concept 5

A class timeline shows that a railroad reached a prairie town in 1872, the town's population tripled by 1880, and a new school opened in 1881. ~~The town's founder was known for his bright red barn.~~ A student writes that the railroad was the only reason the town grew. How should the teacher respond?

Target word: response to a single-cause claim **Decides:** Growth usually has several causes; sequence alone does not prove cause.

A	Correct	Pushes toward multiple causation and evidence rather than a single-cause story.
B	Camouflage	Chases the barn detail, which has nothing to do with causes of growth.
C	Confusion set	Confuses sequence with cause.
D	Absolute language	Replaces one absolute with another; the railroad likely was one cause.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A kindergarten teacher ~~in a busy, newly renovated building~~ wants to introduce maps. ~~The district's new world wall map arrived last week.~~ Which first activity fits how young children build map skills?

Target word: first map activity for young learners **Decides:** Map skills start concrete and familiar, then move to abstract.

A	Camouflage	Uses the new map; distant, symbolic places are the end of the path, not the start.
B	Adjacent category	Coordinate systems are a later, abstract skill.
C	Correct	Moves from a 3-D familiar space to a picture map — the concrete-to-abstract path.
D	Absolute language	Young children can learn maps of familiar spaces.

10. Answer B Concept 7

After a month-long inquiry into litter at a nearby park, a second-grade class found that most trash piles up next to the one broken trash can. ~~The class has an active parent volunteer group and a pet turtle.~~ What is the best informed-action step?

Target word: action that fits the inquiry **Decides:** Action should use the inquiry's evidence and reach someone who can fix the problem.

A	Adjacent category	Service, but unrelated to what the inquiry found.
B	Correct	Grows directly from the evidence and gives students a real decision-maker as the audience.
C	Camouflage	Uses the volunteer detail; adults act, and the root cause is not addressed.
D	Dropped element	Checks learning but drops the action entirely.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A fourth-grade teacher ~~in a room with new flexible seating~~ runs a 30-minute market game in which students trade handmade goods for class tokens. Trading is lively, and the bell rings as it ends. What is the most important next step for learning?

Target word: what makes a simulation teach **Decides:** Learning comes from the debrief that links the game to content.

A	Camouflage	Logistics, not learning; the seating does not decide the next step.
B	Correct	The debrief turns experience into understanding of the economic ideas.
C	Adjacent category	Scores the game outcome rather than understanding of the concepts.
D	Dropped element	Drops the debrief; without it the game is just a game.

12. Answer A Concept 8 · transfer

Which topic should never be taught through a student role-play simulation?

Target word: the forbidden simulation — reverse of running one well **Decides:** Oppression and trauma are not role-played.

A	Correct	Role-playing oppression can harm students and trivialize suffering; use sources and narratives instead.
B	Confusion set	A common, appropriate economics simulation.
C	Inverted operation	A civic process — a fitting simulation.
D	Absolute language	Well-chosen, debriefed simulations are effective.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	5	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Compelling vs. supporting questions	A compelling question is open, enduring, and worth arguing about; supporting questions are narrower and answerable with sources, and they build toward it.	Anchoring an inquiry with a one-fact recall question.	“Which question should anchor the unit / serve as a supporting question?”
2	Primary vs. secondary sources	A primary source was made at the time by a participant or witness; a secondary source interprets the event later.	Calling anything old, or anything about the event, primary.	Who made the item and when, compared with the event’s date.
3	Sourcing a document	Before trusting what a document says, students ask who made it, when, why, and for whom.	Reading a source at face value, or tossing it just because the author had a stake.	A source written by someone with an interest in how events look.
4	Historical empathy vs. presentism	Historical empathy explains past choices using the knowledge, values, and limits of that time; presentism judges the past by today’s standards.	“How would you feel?” tasks that swap evidence for modern feelings.	A task asking students to understand why people in the past acted as they did.
5	Multiple causation	Historical events usually have several causes; coming first on a timeline does not prove cause.	Accepting a single cause because it came first.	A student claim that one thing was “the only reason.”
6	Map skills move from concrete to abstract	Young children learn maps by starting with familiar spaces and 3-D models, then picture maps, then symbolic maps of distant places.	Starting young learners on world maps or coordinate grids.	An early-grade teacher introducing maps for the first time.
7	Taking informed action	Civic action should grow out of the inquiry’s evidence and give students a real audience or decision-maker.	Tacking on unrelated service or a test and calling it action.	“What is the best action step after the inquiry?”
8	Simulations need debriefs and limits	A simulation teaches through the debrief that links the experience to content; oppression and trauma are never role-played.	Treating the activity itself as the lesson, or simulating suffering for realism.	A role-play or game used to teach a social studies idea.

Course scope (public description): Elementary Social Studies Methods is a specialized course designed for learning effective and innovative methods for teaching social studies at the elementary level. This course delves into the best practices for introducing young learners to the complexities of history, geography, civics, economics, and culture. It emphasizes creating engaging, meaningful, and developmentally appropriate learning experiences that foster critical thinking, empathy, and a deeper understanding of the world. This in-depth view of civic engagement fosters effective collaboration and dialogue surrounding the influence of these concepts on our world today. Students learn how to design instruction using themes, concepts, and modes of inquiry throughout the social studies disciplines. By the end of this course, educators gain the skills necessary to inspire a passion for social studies and prepare students to be informed, thoughtful citizens.